



The pace at which the digital revolution is taking place, it will not be long before smart houses are a reality... with the *Digit Zero-One* 2004 awards, we salute the companies—and their products—that help make this revolution come about.

The Digit Test Centre

Another wonderful year has passed by, leaving behind sweet memories of the technologies that emerged across a broad spectrum. While some flickered for moments before going out, others stayed put, and yet others evolved into different incarnations altogether.

This year has seen some dramatic shifts in the way technology is perceived, and the way it will be perceived in the near future. The industry giants are gunning for their ultimate goal—the introduction of the PC into our living rooms. So whether it is the new 915 chipset from Intel, or Microsoft's Media Center OS, the final fantasy is pervasive computing that should *Enable* and *Entertain* you right from the word Go.

Every facet of computing has undergone radical changes in the year that has passed. On the desktop end, Intel took the lead with the introduction of their new desktop platforms—the i915 and the i925 supporting the PCI-Express standard, a technology that will determine the future of motherboards and graphic cards, and in turn the fate of desktop computing. While Intel was successful, arch rival AMD stole some of the limelight with the introduction of truly awesome 64-bit processors that have made the enthusiast community sit up and take notice.

Mobile technology got a shot in the arm with the release of Intel's new Dothan processor. This power-optimised processor per-

forms as well as do high end Pentium 4 processors, but consumes much less power, resulting in low heat dissipation—which in turn means lesser cooling requirements.

Mobile computing is hot, and is manifesting itself in varied forms across all age groups. MP3 players such as the Apple iPod are all the rage amongst young people, and smartphones such as the Sony Ericsson P910 are digital heaven for mobile executives. These smart devices, combined with the proper telecommunication packages, shrink your world to the size of a table-top globe.

Industry bigwigs such as Intel, HP, nVidia, etc. are embracing open source, and are committed to providing drivers for their product lines. This might mean a mighty impact on the adoption of Linux in the SoHo and enterprise segments. Linux distributions are concentrating more on making their products user friendly, and to a certain extent, have succeeded. With KDE 3.3 and Gnome 2.6, the building blocks of the Linux GUI have improved to a level where they can match up to the Windows GUI.

From an Indian perspective, things are shaping up really well. As of today, you can assemble a reasonably good PC for around Rs 20,000. Such affordability is sure to boost PC penetration, and will soon put another million Indians into cyberspace.

Take a look, in the following pages, at the *crème de la crème* of products that have stood out in their respective categories in the year 2004.